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Culture (OWC): [Tonga \(FQ12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1946-1947, 1948, 1950

Coverage Date: 1945-1951

Place Coverage

northeast-central Southern province, Zambia

Section Title(S): CASE XII: PARENTAL CONTROL OF MARRIAGE

People who wish to push through some marriage against the wishes of those concerned have therefore some chance to do so if they are willing to face the hands-off attitude of these people, and to run the risk that their household will never be properly established through the ritual co-operation of the two sets of *basimukowa* and *basyanausi*. In former days, where life and property of all members of a matrilineal group might suffer from the actions of any one member, the policy of non-co-operation was not always applicable. In the event that they feared that their man might involve them disastrously with some other group, they might sell him off into slavery where he could no longer be identified with them, or they might kill him with impunity if they had the consent of his *basyanausi*. If they did not wish to proceed to these lengths, they still had some measure of control in that they could call in their clan joking-partners for a public shaming of the culprit. ¹ This is still done in serious cases of incest, and joking-partners have a general obligation to cast slighting remarks which touch upon one another's misdeeds. But by and large the control of each matrilineal group over its members and over those to whom it stands as *basyanausi* has weakened, and only the policy of non-cooperation remains as a weapon to enforce conformity. With this goes a narrowing of the range within which there is an effective prohibition on intermarriage.

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Approved marriages were either with those classified as cross-cousins or with those to whom there was some previous affinal link, or with clan joking-partners. Marriages with mother's brother's daughter and father's sister's daughter were equally good, and the two types of cross-cousins were terminologically equated. Since this type of preferential marriage clashed with the rules preventing several men of one matrilineal group from marrying women of another matrilineal group, who were closely related to one another,

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it was never possible for most people to conform to it; the marriage of one man blocked that of another. Of the extant marriages in the three census areas of Mujika, Nampeyo, and the Intermediate villages, 22.7 per cent were between cross-cousins real and classificatory, though with real  326 cross-cousins predominating. Marriage with mother's brother's daughter accounted for 12.7 per cent of the marriages, that with father's sister's daughter for the other 10 per cent.

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¹ See Colson, 1953 *b*.

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